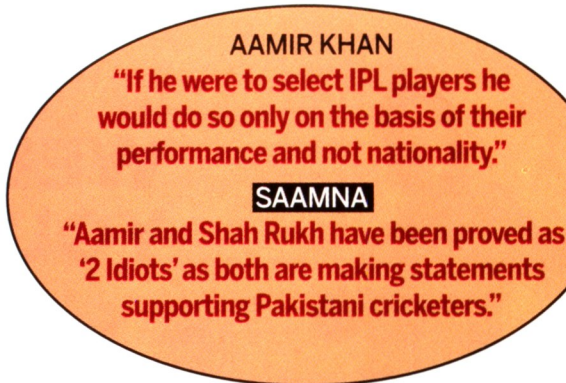


States **MAHARASHTRA**

comment on north Indian NSG commandos being flown in to Mumbai during 26/11, Uddhav and his team went into a huddle looking for a new strategy. On February 3, he slammed the Congress Government by calling the chief minister anti-Marathi. He didn't even spare the RSS. Not to be left out, Chavan—under pressure from allies and the leadership in Delhi—met with the press. In true Congress tradition, Maharashtra Pradesh Congress chief Manikrao Thakre declared that "Rahul Gandhi played a crucial role and took a stand on an issue of national importance. He meant that the whole nation comes together in a time of crisis and does not

RAJ THACKERAY HAS BEEN TAKING POT SHOTS AT NORTH INDIANS



think if he's a Maharashtrian."

While Uddhav has been on a rant and rave mission, cousin Raj has come up with his own salvo. Addressing a rally on the same day, Raj rubbished Rahul's statement that "north Indians saved Mumbai during 26/11". He asked why Rahul and his predecessors did not bother to develop Uttar Pradesh though all of them contested elections from the state. Raj says, "Rahul's grandmother Indiraji had appointed General Arunkumar Vaidya, a Maharashtrian, to lead Operation Blue Star to eliminate terrorists in Amritsar. We never said that Maharashtra saved Punjab."

This cub didn't even spare the industrialists and took pot shots on RSS functionary Ram Madhav and Ambani for their "Mumbai for all" remarks. He says, "They say Mumbai belongs to India. When did I say Mumbai belongs to Afghanistan or China? I am not against the country's integrity. The 26/11 attack was Delhi's intelligence failure and you are blaming Maharashtra for that."

The problem is one of objective. In their quest to outdo Raj, Uddhav and the Shiv Sena have not just antagonised national icons and alienated their own followers, they seem to be on the verge of losing their oldest ally, the BJP. With the RSS asking their Sangh Parivar to protect north Indians in Maharashtra, the rift between the BJP and the Shiv Sena has come out in the open. It's a well-known fact that Gadkari and Uddhav have never been the best of friends and that the BJP at one time was actively considering tying up with MNS because of Uddhav's high-handedness. With the BJP coming out in

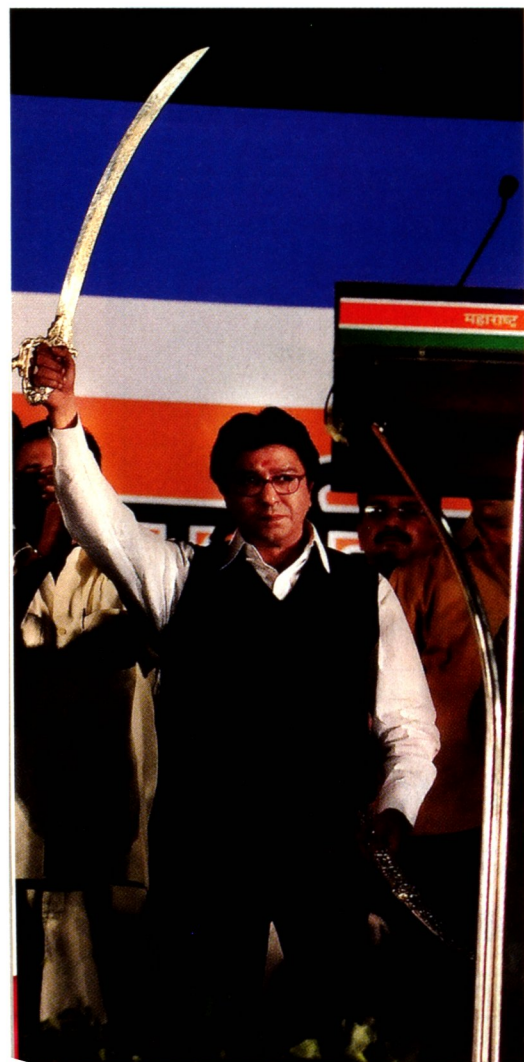
the open with its stand against regionalism, its alliance with the Sena seems to be skating on thin ice. By likening the Sena's view on Mumbai to Article 370 and granting special status to Jammu & Kashmir, Gadkari has made it clear to the BJP's alliance partner that it's not going to remain silent on the Sena's regional agenda.

The fusillade of poor publicity seems to have hit home at Matoshri. In a face saving move, Uddhav has softened his stance on demanding an "apology from Shah Rukh Khan". Uddhav says, "We have no issues against Shah Rukh Khan's film (*My Name Is Khan*) and neither have we told any theatre owner not to screen his film. Our problem is with his stand on Pakistani players. It is up to him now whether to change his stand or stick to it." For now, there seems to be a commercial break in the tamasha, but both the Centre and the state Government will have to act if they don't want the nation's commercial capital to be turned into the theatre of the absurd like in a banana republic. Both the Centre and the state will have to address the concerns arising out of Mumbai.

Piyush Pandey, executive chairman and national creative director of Ogilvy & Mather, puts it succinctly for the political class, "The Government must have a proper discussion, not in the media, and convey it to the public at large; else people will live with insecurity. There has to be a dialogue on what kind of a country we are and where do people stand in the city of Mumbai." ■



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